



Action Planning + Problem Solving

What is Action Planning?

Action planning is when you create a plan of the behaviour you hope to perform, taking into account *what, when, where, and how* you are going to do the behaviour.



Research confirms that action planning can effectively improve and reinforce physical activity behaviour by breaking down physical activity into manageable components.

An action plan contains four main components:

WHAT: The type of physical activity you are doing. For example, yoga, strength training, wheelchair basketball, walking.

WHEN: The frequency, timing. Which days of the week? At what time? For example, Mondays at 2pm, Wednesdays at 6pm, Saturdays at 9am.

WHERE: The exact location of the physical activity. For example, at the fitness centre.

HOW: The context, process, or details of the physical activity. For example, the duration of your walk will be 30 minutes.

What is Problem Solving?

Problem solving is creating a plan for overcoming obstacles that might hinder your progress or stop you from achieving your goals.



Using both action planning and problem solving together has been shown to be more useful and beneficial than only using an action plan.

First, identify the barriers that could potentially stop you from completing your action plan. Second, create an alternative plan to manage these barriers. You can use an **If/Then Statement** to state your problem solving plan; for example, ***if** I am feeling too tired today, **then** I will do my physical activity tomorrow.*

Types of barriers you might face:

Environmental	Social	Physical	Emotional	Cognitive
Space, time, finances, material, weather	Social support or cultural norms of family, friends, peers	Skills, strength, physical wellbeing	Mental wellbeing, negative emotions	Thought processes or habits

CASE STUDY

Action planning: Sam has asthma, which can make it difficult for him to run long distances. His goal is to run 12 km per week. He decides to write down an action plan to help him reach his goal.

Problem solving: One of the obstacles Sam identifies is that it might thunderstorm when he wants to go outside for his run. The if/then statement he creates is:



IF it thunderstorms outside, **THEN** I will run on the treadmill at the athletics centre gym.



Mondays & Wednesdays:

What: Run

When: 5pm

Where: public park near house

How: run for 3 km

Thursdays & Saturdays:

What: Run

When: 9am

Where: along the canal

How: run for 3 km



Your Turn

How do you use it?

ACTION PLANNING

1. Create a Plan

Based on the physical activity goal you’ve created, create a detailed plan for how you will work towards achieving it. You can use the following chart to create your action plan. Make sure you answer when, where, what and how you will achieve your goal.

	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
WHAT: <i>what physical activity will you do?</i>							
WHEN: <i>when will you do it?</i>							
WHERE: <i>where will you do it?</i>							
HOW: <i>how will you do it?</i>							

2. Remind Yourself Of Your Plan

Write your plan somewhere that you will check. or example, in a calendar or by setting reminders on your phone.

What will you do to remind yourself of your plan?



Your Turn

How do you use it?

PROBLEM SOLVING

1. Identify

Think about what might prevent you from achieving your goals. Identify 2 or 3 of your most important barriers.

What type of barriers do you think you are facing?

- ☐ **ENVIRONMENTAL:** *space, time, finances, material, weather*
- ☐ **SOCIAL:** *social support or cultural norms*
- ☐ **PHYSICAL:** *skills, strength, physical wellbeing*
- ☐ **EMOTIONAL:** *mental wellbeing, negative emotions*
- ☐ **COGNITIVE:** *thought processes, habits*

What are some barriers you face regarding your physical activity?

2. Find Alternatives

Find at least one alternative to each barrier. Write down some alternative/strategies to overcome each barrier.

3. Create If/Then statements

If/Then statements allow you to indicate the barrier and the alternative in a succinct statement.

IF __[insert barrier]__, **THEN** __[insert alternative]__.

IF:		THEN:	
IF:		THEN:	



Reflection – *Action Planning + Problem Solving*

Reflect on your experience practicing and using action planning this week. Use this space to write your overall impressions of using this skill. Respond to the reflection questions below:

- Did my action plan help me to accomplish my goals? How?
- Is there anything I need to change about my action plan? How will I continue to use action planning in the future?
- Did problem solving help me deal with setbacks better? If not, what can I change to help me more?
- Where am I recording my action plan and problem solving plans?